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Staggered Inequalities in Access to Higher Education by Gender, Race, and Ethnicity

RUTH ENID ZAMBRANA AND VICTORIA-MARÍA MACDONALD

In institutions of higher learning, the retention and persistence of underrepresented racial and ethnic groups has come to the forefront as the economic and social value of a baccalaureate degree increases (Orfield, Marin, & Horn, 2005; Tinto, 1987, 1988).¹ After making rapid gains in the late 1960s and early 1980s, the enrollment of historically underrepresented groups, namely African Americans, Mexican Americans, and Puerto Ricans, began to stall in the late 1980s, increasing again only in the late 1990s (Price & Wohlford, 2005). Latina/o youth actually increased enrollment in higher education during the 1990s but persistence to degree remained elusive (Suro & Fry, 2005). Their enrollment is clustered disproportionately in community colleges that have a poor record of transferring students to four-year colleges. Studies on Latinos and African Americans in higher education have remained remarkably silent on gender issues. With the exception of the American Association of University Women's landmark 2001 study on Latinas in school (Ginorio & Huston, 2001), the emphasis remains upon aggregate data (e.g., Tienda & Mitchell, 2006). Gender differences have been highlighted in the past decade as a result of the growing gap between male and female baccalaureate degree holders among African Americans, Mexican American, and non-Hispanic Whites (NHW), as women outpace their male counterparts (Price & Wohlford, 2005; González, Jovel, & Stoner, 2004). However, educational disparities by socioeconomic status (SES), race, and ethnicity among women in access to U.S. higher education have been less studied but are important to illuminate factors associated with completion of higher education that are unique to women from different ethnic groups.

Among all baccalaureate degrees awarded to women in 1990, 84 percent were awarded to non-Hispanic Whites, 7 percent to African American women,

TABLE 4.1
Percent (%) of Bachelor’s and Doctoral Degrees Granted to
Non-Hispanic White, African American, and Latino Women,
1980, 1990, and 2000

	1980	1990	2000	Point Change
NHW B.A.	86	84	75	– 11
NHW Ph.D.	84	76	67	– 17
AA B.A.	7.8	7	10.3	+2.5
AA Ph.D.	5.6	4.5	6.7	+1.1
Latina B.A.	2.4	3.5	6.5	+4.1
Latina Ph.D.	1.7	2.5	4.1	+2.4

Source: Table 261, Bachelor’s degrees conferred by degree-granting institutions, by racial/ethnic group & sex of student, 1976–77 through 2003–04 and Table 267, Doctoral degrees conferred by degree-granting institutions, by racial/ethnic group & sex of student, 1976–77 through 2003–04, National Center for Education Statistics (<http://nces.ed.gov> accessed May 16, 2007).

and only 3.5 percent to Latino women.² Three-quarters of all female doctoral degrees were awarded to non-Hispanic Whites in 1990, with African Americans receiving 4.5 percent and Latinas 2.5 percent.³ By 2000 the numbers had crept up for African American and Latino women, receiving 6.7 percent and 4.1 percent, respectively, of all doctoral degrees. According to scholars examining parity in doctoral production, between 1990 and 2000, Mexican American women remain the most underrepresented group among all female doctoral recipients and have the lowest rates of degree attainment among all Latino women (Watford, et al., 2006). Among the 358 Latino women receiving doctoral degrees in 1990, less than one-fourth were Mexican American, and in 2000 less than one-third (1.6 percent vs. 4.1 percent) of all doctoral recipients were Mexican American despite their larger numbers in the general Latina population (Watford, et al., 2006). This finding is not surprising, as Mexican Americans, representing two-thirds of all Hispanics in the United States, have experienced systematic and persistent oppression and inequality since the 1848 Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo that ended the Mexican American War. These data emphasize the importance of examining women’s experiences in sociohistorical contexts and interrogating how prior treatment has shaped barriers over time to differentially impede the educational attainment of Mexican American women in comparison to other women.

The analytic approach derives its grounding from an intersectional perspective to examine factors that facilitated or hindered higher education

attainment. Using an intersectional framework allows one to examine patterns of educational attainment by taking into account historical relations of power that shape institutions in which historically underrepresented women participated, and patterns of inequality which include both hegemonic and disciplinary power in the educational pipeline (Hill-Collins, 2000; Dill & Zambrana, in this volume, chapter 1).

Five explicit assumptions are inherent in the intersectional lens. First, race, ethnicity, SES, and gender are co-constitutive and mutually reinforcing dimensions that shape one's life chances, opportunities, and, in turn, experiences in higher education. Second, access to public educational systems with limited resources and privilege is simultaneously shaped by the intersection of race, ethnicity, gender, and SES. Third, structural barriers, such as the increasingly resegregated conditions of urban majority/minority secondary schools, are limiting educational preparedness for Latino and African American youth. Fourth, stereotypic representations of students as inferior permeate the attitudes of school personnel that contribute to Mexican American and African American women seen as not desiring or wanting to succeed academically. Fifth, institutional factors such as the role of teachers and administrators in K-12 schools have contributed to the academic disengagement of Mexican American and African American youth, dampening educational expectations and aspirations. Using gender as the sole category of analysis and centering generic women's experiences in education essentializes the experiences of non-White women and masks the historic patterns of racial inequality that have shaped past and current access to and completion of higher education among historically underrepresented women. In this chapter we examine historical, social, and institutional factors among non-Hispanic White, African American, and Mexican American women who received higher education degrees during the late 1960s through the 1980s. This study aims to identify and compare pre-college experiences and reported barriers in higher education associated with perceived institutional stress and academic difficulty. These experiences are informed by the history of women in higher education in the United States.

History of U.S. Women's Access to Higher Education: Staggered Inequality

Although in the colonial period, native-born White women were denied access to colonial colleges and local schools (Solomon, 1985; Tyack & Hansot, 1990), during the nineteenth century, "social utility" arguments were used to justify higher learning for White women. Arguments for access included the need to: develop future citizens of the republic; train girls to become good mothers; train women to enter teaching; and civilize waves of immigrants entering the United States. By the early 1900s, native-born White women were entering

postsecondary institutions reaching parity in numbers with men. The proliferation of state-supported normal (teaching) schools created a higher education pipeline for them, often offering free tuition in exchange for commitment to teach for a certain period after graduation (Ogren, 2005; McCandless, 1999).

African American women in the South were denied the right to any education before 1865. At the time of emancipation, historians estimate that only 10 percent of the African American population could read or write. The federal government's creation of the Bureau of Refugees, Freedmen, and Abandoned Lands (Freedmen's Bureau), religious missionary organizations, and African American communities themselves helped create hundreds of schools for children and adults in the Reconstruction period (Anderson, 1988; Williams, 2005). The establishment of Howard University in 1867 was the U.S. government's first investment in higher education for African Americans. The Second Morrill Act of 1890 required the Southern states to create segregated and equal public universities for Blacks or to admit Blacks into Southern public institutions. The increase in Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) in the early twentieth century contributed to the pool of African American college graduates who constituted the foundation of a Black middle class and became a vanguard in the push for civil rights in education. In addition, through the creation of sororities, African American women with college degrees, who regarded their role as critical ones in the "racial uplift" of less privileged women (Perkins, 1983), worked to support and further education for their communities. Given formal status at the Howard University campus in 1908, Alpha Kappa Alpha (AKA) was the first Black sorority, founded fifty-seven years after the country's first White sorority, Alpha Delta Pi (Gasman, 2005). For Black women, HBCUs and sororities became the "purveyors" of social capital and vocal supporters of increasing educational opportunities for Black women (Mercomes, 1998). During the years that the African American women in this study began college, opportunities in higher education had expanded to include more predominantly all-White institutions (Samuels, 2004). Within these integrated yet predominantly White institutions, African American women broke away from traditional expectations for their gender in the Black community while simultaneously breaking racial barriers (Higginbotham, 2001).

"Triple Oppression": Class, Gender, and Race/Ethnicity

Since the 1800s, Mexican American women's participation in higher education has been limited. Incorporation of Mexican Americans into the United States through conquest as a result of the Mexican American War in 1848 combined with the federal government's legislative, judicial, and monetary power delayed access to higher education. As a result, the initial push for educational access

among Latinos focused on the lower levels of schooling (MacDonald, Botti, & Hoffman Clark, 2007). Testimony from civil rights hearings, court depositions, and first-person interviews during the civil rights era reveal that it was an unofficial practice to bar Latinos from attending high school in the Southwest. Even until 1960, the highest level of education for the majority of Latinos in the Southwest was eighth grade (Donato, 1997), and they comprised fewer than 6 percent of entering college students in 1958 (Carter, 1970).⁴ While Mexican Americans pursued equity in educational arenas during the early twentieth century through civic organizations such as the League of United Latin American Citizens (LULAC), the early desegregation cases focused on K–8 schools where Mexican American children were clustered. As a result of systematic and structured discrimination against Mexican American youth in the Southwest, Mexican American women were often excluded from government-supported programs in higher education (MacDonald, Botti, & Hoffman Clark, 2007).

When Denise Segura identified the “triple oppression” of Mexican American (Chicana) women in the labor force (1984, 1990) she was also speaking to Mexican American women entering higher education in the early 1960s hoping to broaden their horizons from those of their mothers. Mexican Americans were the last to access higher education. Their entry as a significant presence only began in the mid- to late twentieth century and is first seen in women’s Catholic Colleges, two-year schools, and teacher training institutions. (MacDonald, 2004; MacDonald & Garcia, 2003).

Fijese Papá que entré al Student National Education Association (SNEA) porque nos dijo la monja que “it would look good in our record” pero tuvimos que pagar las “fee” y como soy miembro nuevo tengo que pagar \$5.50. No lo pagui [sic] yo porque el dinero que me mando lo utilize en los libros que compre y aparte tuve que pagar un “fee” en Music Education, compre typing paper, 1 Red pencil y otras cosas que me faltaban y tenía que comprar así es que me quedé sin dinero.

[Look Dad, I joined the Student National Education Association (SNEA) because the nun said that “it would look good in our record” but we had to pay a “fee” and since I am a new member I have to pay \$5.50. I didn’t pay it because the money that you sent I used it to buy books and aside from that I had to pay a “fee” in Music Education, I bought typing paper, 1 Red pencil and other things that I needed to buy and that’s how I am left without money.]

Letter from Rosa C. Martinez
Our Lady of Lakes College,
San Antonio, TX, October 9, 1961.

(Papers of Mercurio Martinez, Texas A&M Archives, College Station, TX)

The student above, Rosa C. Martinez, had taken out a loan from the U.S. National Defense Student Loan Fund. Although her father was one of the first certified Mexican American teachers in Texas and a small town mayor, sending a daughter to college was almost prohibitive for the family. He exhorted her to watch her money because it was “sangre del corazon” (blood from the heart) and several family members contributed clothes and supplies for Rosa to attend (Letter from Mercurio Martinez, Laredo, Texas, October 24, 1961). Rosa’s story is just one of hundreds and then thousands of stories of the first generation of Latino women to enter higher education in the 1960s and 1970s. In so doing, these pioneers faced significant barriers both institutionally and as a result of gender and race discrimination as well as socioeconomic status.

As late as 1978 when this study’s cohort was in higher education, institutions with the highest numbers of Mexican Americans and Latinos were East Los Angeles College (two year); Miami Dade Community College (two year); and private schools such as Our Lady of Lakes University in Texas (Brown, Rosen, & Hill, 1980, table 3.15). Different from African American women, Mexican American women lacked successful counterparts to HBCUs and the resulting network of college graduates or sororities. In fact, the first Latina sorority in the United States, Lambda Theta Alpha at Kean University (New Jersey) was not founded until 1975. Most Latina sororities were founded in the 1990s and continue to be created as Latina women recognize the support and social capital advantages that lifelong membership in a sorority can bring (www.latinogreek.com).

Historical data support a staggered inequality model by which historically underrepresented women have attained higher education. Historicizing our understanding of access to higher education demonstrates how hegemonic power has differentially shaped access to educational institutions for African American and Mexican American women, and for non-Hispanic White women who have been beneficiaries of unacknowledged privilege. These historical patterns continue post-civil rights legislation and are embedded and reproduced in the educational pipeline.

Institutional Patterns in Pre-College Educational Pipeline

Pre-college preparation is associated with academic difficulty and stress in higher education (Capello, 1994; Reyes, 2001; Rodriguez, et al., 2000; Gandara, 2006). High school grade point average (HSGPA), advanced placement courses and the perception of an individual’s ability, and prior encouragement from school personnel are major criteria of entry and access to higher education and major factors in understanding racial and ethnic disparities (Farkas, 2003; Teranishi, Allen, & Solórzano, 2004). Using HSGPA as a predictor of college performance has been well studied for non-Hispanic White students, but less so for African Americans and Mexican American students (Allen, 1985; Johnson,

1986; Smith & Allen, 1984). Using HSGPA to predict academic success in various fields shows that both non-Hispanic White and African American women tend to have higher grade point averages (GPA) than non-Hispanic White and African American men (Allen & Haniff, 1991; Solomon, 1992; Astin & Cross, 1981; Smith, 1991). HSGPA however is strongly associated with school resources, geographic location, and attitudes of high school personnel toward students of African American and Mexican American origin.

School environments for a significant number of African American and Mexican American girls are not conducive to academic achievement (Dance, in this volume, chapter 8). Experiences of Latinas from elementary to postsecondary education show that teachers often overlook, ignore, and avoid Latinas in the classroom while preferring to interact with Anglo males (Pizarro, 2005; Ginorio & Huston, 2001). Mexican American girls begin the process of leaving school earlier than African American and non-Hispanic White girls (Astin, 1982; Del Castillo, et al., 1988; Nielson & Fernandez, 1982; Rumberger, 1988; Zambrana & Zoppi, 2002) and dropout to assist families economically with child-care or because of their own pregnancies (Ginorio & Huston, 2001). Teachers, and even Mexican Americans themselves, often attribute Latino academic success to luck or to factors other than ability (Lee, 1988; Cuádriz, 1999). Mexican American girls tend to have the highest high school dropout rates as a result of the intersection of low-socioeconomic status and limited encouragement to succeed academically, which narrows their perceived life options.

Educational segregation, which characterizes many public schools in urban areas that educate the majority of Black and Latino students, is problematic (Orfield & Eaton, 1996). Segregation by race, ethnicity, and low SES all too frequently is accompanied by lack of adequate resources such as comprehensive libraries and computers, poorly qualified teachers, lack of advanced placement classes, and lack of the social and cultural capital that non-Hispanic White, middle-class students accrue in affluent suburban public schools. The absence of these resources negatively affects Latino and African American students' opportunities to access higher education (Teranishi, Allen, & Solórzano, 2004). In an influential study, Swail, Cabrera, & Lee (2004) found, among other factors, that for Latino students to persist through completion of a four-year degree they needed to have a plan by the eighth grade that included knowing that students needed to take Algebra I by the ninth grade to be competitive for college. This type of information has often been difficult for Latino parents to access, particularly because of language barriers, discrimination by school counselors and personnel, economic necessities requiring two or more jobs, and transportation problems, thus precluding attendance at school meetings (Auerbach, 2002; Zoppi, MacDonald, & Munoz, 2007; Loza, 2003). For those African American and Mexican American students who successfully navigate the pre-college pipeline, adjustment to predominantly non-Hispanic White

environments present new challenges (Cuádras, 1999). According to Higginbotham (2001, 15), institutions of higher education are still "sites of routine and periodic trauma for African Americans and many other students of color."

Higher Education Institutions: Barriers to Adjustment

Multiple factors have been identified as important to persistence in higher education among women. These include: family socioeconomic status and gender discrimination (Epstein, 1970; Almquist, 1974); and lack of support from professors and financial support (Gloria, et al., 2005). Prior research on non-Hispanic White women's experiences in the 1970s confirm overt gender discrimination in admission and financial aid practices, in institutional regulations, and in faculty attitudes and behavior (Furniss & Graham, 1974; Kutner & Brogan, 1976; Roby, 1975). Women reported not receiving enough financial support (Howard-Vital, 1987), and were often reluctant to obtain additional loans to pay for graduate education (Farley & Allen, 1987). They also reported feeling isolated, lonely, and invisible (Dinwiddie & Allen, 2003); less likely to be chosen as protégés of influential male faculty, thus resulting in the loss of benefits that such a relationship has on later career opportunities (Allen & Haniff, 1991; Feldman, 1974; Moses, 1989); and being harassed by the use of demeaning comments about women, sexual jokes, and outright hazing (Bernard, 1976; Holahan, 1979).

For African American and Mexican American women, race, ethnic, and gender discrimination (Jackson, 1998; Reyes, 2001) and social and academic adjustment to a predominantly White environment all may contribute to academic difficulty and perceived stress (Howard-Vital, 1987; Mortenson, 1991; Solomon, 1992; Castillo, et al., 2004; Williams, 2005). Historically underrepresented students who come from ethnically homogenous community and school environments often experience feelings of isolation and alienation, have less contact with peers, are less often engaged in social activities (Padilla, 1997; Benjamin, 1982; Fleming, 1983; Capello, 1994), are less likely to receive encouragement from counselors and advisors to pursue graduate training (King, 2007; Howard-Vital, 1987), and may not get to know faculty members who can write letters of recommendation or help them secure financial assistance (Jacobs, 1981; Carroll, 1982). Banks (1988), in a study of African American female law students found that they volunteered less often in the classroom than men, believed that their professors often ignored them or overlooked them when they did volunteer, and had less access than non-Hispanic White women or racial and ethnic men to informal interaction, such as having lunch, with their advisors outside the advisor-advisee relationship.

Adjustment to college involves both an academic transition as well as a cultural one for racial and ethnic women (Chacon, 1982; Wolf-Wendel, 1998; Munoz & Garcia-Bahne, 1978; Squires-Nieves, 1991; Aguilar, 1996). Adjustment in higher

education institutions among African American and Mexican American women is often associated with being first generation college students, perceived discrimination, personal and familial issues, and pre-college academic preparation, which may contribute to high levels of perceived stress and low levels of perceived institutional support (González, Jovel, & Stoner, 2004; Anchor & Morales, 1990; Rodriguez, et al., 2000). Students who are the first generation in their families to attend college may experience higher stress, which has a negative impact upon persistence. The knowledge of parents who have attended college facilitates academic and social adjustment of their children (Choy, 2001). For example, in a study of Latino college students in 1976 living with their parents, only 11 percent of these students had parents who were college graduates compared to over one-third of the non-Hispanic White students (Brown, Rosen, & Hill, 1980, table 3.37). Another study conducted in Austin, Texas (Mendoza, 1981) found that both non-Hispanic White and Mexican American women experienced more stress than men in academic, personal and familial issues. A recent study confirmed an earlier study (Chacon, 1982) that found that comfort with White cultural values, perceived support from family, and financial support, were related to lower perceived stress among Mexican American female college students (Castillo, Conoley, & Brossart, 2004).

An additional barrier to women is the lack of female faculty role models and mentors. Tidball (1980) reported that as the proportion of women faculty relative to the number of women students increases, so does the proportion of women high achievers in professional life. Among faculty in U.S. colleges and universities, Latinos (men and women) comprise only 3.5 percent of all faculty (NCES, 2003). The relative lack of female faculty is a deterrent to women's educational and career pursuits (Mortenson, 1991; O'Donnell & Anderson, 1978; Solomon & Wingard, 1991). In 1985 while the cohort of women in this study was obtaining higher education degrees, African American women constituted only 1.9 percent of full-time faculty in higher education, 0.6 percent of full professors, 1.4 percent of associate professors, 2.7 percent of assistant professors, and 3 percent of instructors and lecturers (Cole, 1988). Gregory (2001) reports that Black women account for only 6.43 percent of all full-time faculties, and one-half of these women are employed at HBCUs. Only 1 percent of Black women PhDs teach full-time in four-year universities. Although non-Hispanic White women students and faculty have increased significantly in higher education, in 2003, African Americans and Latinos held 5.5 percent and 3.5 percent of all faculty positions respectively (NCES, 2003). Collectively African American and Latino faculty comprise only 5 percent of all full-professors nationwide (NCES, 2001). Among women as percent of all faculty, only 2.9 percent of all those with tenure were African American or Latina in 2001 in contrast to 25.9 percent of non-Hispanic White women. The numbers of tenure-track faculty for the two historically underrepresented groups in all major universities have remained

stagnant for almost three decades, as has the progress made by increased enrollment of historically underrepresented students in higher education systems. Recent events suggest that the "chilly climate" for non-Hispanic Whites may be slowly experiencing a small thaw. For example, in 2007 one-half of Ivy League institutions are headed by women, six non-Hispanic Whites and one African American. Non-Hispanic White women have achieved considerable progress toward parity in higher education while African American and Mexican American women still lag noticeably behind.

The sparse data on higher education experiences of Mexican American women suggest that they may experience more stressors due to ethnic, racial, and class discrimination resulting from educators' stereotypic expectations of lower ability and performance by Latino students and the lack of Latino faculty and administrators who can provide mentorship and emotional support for them during their higher education experiences (Rodriguez, et al., 2000; Castillo, et al., 2004).

Methodology

Sample and Procedures

Data employed in this study were derived from interviews with three hundred Mexican American, one hundred African American, and one hundred non-Hispanic White women who lived in the Los Angeles area and had completed a higher education degree (ranging from a bachelor's degree to a doctorate) during the late 1960s through mid-1980s. The criteria for sample selection were: ethnicity; completion of secondary and higher education experiences in the United States; and English as the primary language. A purposive, network sampling approach was used. Study protocol and procedures were reviewed and approved by the UCLA Human Subjects Committee. Respondents were contacted by telephone and explained the nature of the study. After informed consent was provided, respondents who agreed were then administered the questionnaire during the years 1987–1990. All questionnaires were completed in English. As a nonprobability sampling method was utilized in this cross-sectional study, the population studied is not representative of all women in higher education in the three racial/ethnic groups and the findings cannot be generalized. However, the findings do suggest important descriptive results and provide a unique opportunity to look at Mexican American women who are relatively invisible in higher education in comparison to non-Hispanic White and African American women.

Measures

The questionnaire consisted of 233 items and included both open-ended and closed-ended response options. Data were obtained on current sociodemographic

characteristics of respondents, private vs. public high school attended, academic predictors including high school and undergraduate GPA, work status during higher education, type of higher education institution attended, institutional resources available such as loans and scholarships, perception of institutional stressors, and perceptions of institutional or academic support.

A series of items asked the respondent to report on their high school experiences and included items on perceptions of high school performance, excellence in particular subjects, perception of teacher encouragement for college attendance, and whether they felt high school prepared them for college. Several items obtained data on residence during undergraduate education, employment status, number of hours worked, and type of institution attended. Academic performance indicators were measured by self-report of high school and college grade point average (GPA). Another series of questions asked the respondent to report on their undergraduate experiences and included items on whether they perceived racial discrimination to be a problem for women, whether they experienced racial and/or sex discrimination as a problem, and whether they perceived that the educational experience was harder for minority women. In addition, data were obtained on whether they experienced academic, emotional, and/or social difficulties.

The major dependent variables were the perception of stress and reported academic difficulty during the undergraduate experience. A stress scale consisting of sixteen items asked respondents to rate the degree of stress from 1 = not stressful to 5 = highly stressful during the pursuit of their higher education. The areas included educational demands, marital companionship pressures, immediate family pressures, financial, health, childcare, social life, and academic and institutional pressures. The reliability analysis on this scale yielded a Cronbach alpha of .85.⁵ A single item asked the respondents to rate their overall academic difficulty on a four-item Likert scale, where 4 = very difficult, 3 = somewhat difficult, 2 = difficult, and 1 = not difficult. Descriptive univariate and bivariate statistics to examine similarities and differences by race/ethnicity on the major study variables were conducted. Multivariate analyses were also run to assess the relationships of selected factors on perceived academic difficulty and perceived level of stress by ethnic group.

Results

Description of the Sample

The median age of participants was thirty-five years with no significant difference across ethnic groups. A higher percentage of non-Hispanic White women were single (37 percent) or married (54 percent) while a lower percentage were separated or divorced, 9 percent as compared to 28.3 percent of the African American women and 19.6 percent of the Mexican American women. Less than

40 percent of the non-Hispanic White women had one or more children compared to almost 60 percent of African American and 50 percent of Mexican American women. The majority of all women worked full-time. Just over 65 percent of all the women had completed a masters and/or doctoral degree. Ninety percent of the respondents received their bachelor's degree by 1978. Those who pursued postbachelor's degrees received their degrees by 1988.

The current socioeconomic status (SES) of the respondents as measured by education, income, and occupation revealed that the majority of all the women were in high or high-middle SES (94.6 percent of the Mexican American women and 75.3 percent of the African American and White women). This is in sharp contrast to the socioeconomic status of their families of origin as indicated by their fathers' socioeconomic status. Fifty-six percent of the Mexican American women and 48 percent of the African American women, as compared to 20 percent of the White women, reported low-middle or low SES. Just over half of the non-Hispanic White women (52.10 percent) compared to 30 percent of the African American and 13 percent of the Mexican American women came from upper or upper-middle SES homes. It has been shown that higher SES non-Hispanic White women are more likely to volunteer for studies than non-Hispanic White women from working-class or low-SES background (Weber, Higginbotham, & Leung, 1999).

Pre-College Educational Experiences

In high school, Mexican American women were more likely to have attended parochial schools (31.3 percent) than either the African American women (11.2 percent) or the non-Hispanic White women (19 percent). As shown in table 4.2, during high school, the majority of all the women (over 80 percent) reported being in a college bound group and performing well in school, though a significantly larger number of Mexican American women reported not performing well (11 percent) compared to the other two groups. However, close to half of all respondents indicated that they did not feel that high school had prepared them well for college.

The average high school GPA (HSGPA) for all the women was 3.41. On the other hand, their experience with high school teachers varied significantly across groups. Mexican American women were less likely to have been encouraged by their teachers to go on to college and more likely to have been encouraged to go to a trade school followed by African American and then non-Hispanic White women. The majority of all the women entered college directly after high school with no significant variation across groups.

The trends change, however, at the undergraduate level. As shown in table 4.3, African American women (33 percent) were significantly most likely to have attended private colleges and Mexican Americans (18 percent) least likely. However, average college GPA scores differed across groups with non-Hispanic

TABLE 4.2
High School Experiences by Ethnic Group

<i>High School Characteristic</i>	<i>Mexican American (300)</i>	<i>African American (100)</i>	<i>White (100)</i>
Type of High School:			
Public	68.70%	88.80%	81.00%
Private	31.30%	11.20%	19.00%
($X^2(2) = 19.76, p < .01$)			
In College Bound Group:			
Yes	83.10%	85.20%	86.50%
Performed Well:			
Yes	89.10%	95.90%	99.00%
($X^2(2) = 15.68, p < .01$)			
Excelled in Subject(s):			
Particular Subject	66.90%	53.50%	38.10%
All Subjects	27.40%	41.40%	49.50%
No Subjects	5.70%	5.10%	12.40%
($X^2(4) = 27.84, p < .01$)			
Well Prepared for College:			
Yes	51.90%	41.10%	44.90%
Grade Point Average (GPA):			
Mean	3.37	3.41	3.46
(SD)	(0.47)	(0.51)	(0.47)
Teachers:			
Encouraged Going to College:			
Yes	66.60%	86.60%	91.00%
($X^2(2) = 35.25, p < .01$)			
Encouraged Trade School:			
Yes	26.80%	19.20%	14.00%
($X^2(2) = 8.22, p < .05$)			

White women reporting significantly higher college GPA scores on average (3.36) than either the Mexican American (3.20) or African American (3.15) women.

During their undergraduate experience, almost twice as many Mexican American women (29 percent) as African American or non-Hispanic White women reported living with their parent(s), while more African Americans (45 percent) reported living on campus. This higher percentage of Mexican

TABLE 4.3
Undergraduate Characteristics by Ethnic Group

<i>Undergraduate School Characteristic</i>	<i>Mexican American (300)</i>	<i>African American (100)</i>	<i>White (100)</i>
Type of Institution:			
Public	82.10%	67.40%	74.20%
Private	17.90%	32.60%	25.80%
($X^2(2) = 9.16, p = .01$)			
Grade Point Average: (GPA)			
Mean	3.20	3.15	3.36
(SD)	(0.42)	(0.42)	(0.36)
($F(2) = 6.59, \text{Sig } F < .01$)			
Residence:			
With Parent(s)	28.90%	14.30%	15.50%
Campus Residence Hall	20.10%	44.90%	28.90%
Off Campus	51.00%	40.80%	55.70%
($X^2(4) = 28.47, p < .01$)			
Employment:			
Full-Time	12.67%	20.60%	10.80%
Part-Time	76.33%	43.04%	66.20%
Did Not Work	11.00%	36.36%	23.00%
($X^2(4) = 34.43, p < .01$)			
Received Scholarships:			
Yes	45.67%	49.50%	23.00%
($X^2(2) = 39.07, p < .01$)			
Received Student Loans:			
Yes	32.33%	35.35%	22.00%
($X^2(2) = 18.48, p < .05$)			

American women living with their parents may reflect cultural practices, which prefer keeping young women under a watchful eye, and financial concerns regarding housing on campus. The group with the largest number of women who reported working full-time during college was African American (21 percent) and that group also reported the highest percentage (36 percent) of women who did not work at all during college. Just under half of the Mexican American and African American women indicated they had received some form of financial scholarship during college as compared to 23 percent of non-Hispanic White women. Approximately one-third of the racial-ethnic

women received student loans compared to 22 percent of non-Hispanic White women. This finding reflects differences in social class background.

Experiencing Higher Education: Discrimination, Difficulties, and Stress

Educational climate is critical for learning and educational success. Table 4.4 shows that Mexican American (68 percent) and particularly African American women (77 percent) reported experiencing racial discrimination in their relationships with professors and peers, compared to 19 percent of non-Hispanic White women. However, approximately half of all the women reported sex discrimination as a problem while pursuing their undergraduate education with a slightly lower percentage of African American women reporting sex discrimination (43 percent) compared to Mexican American (58 percent) and non-Hispanic White women (50 percent). On the whole, almost 90 percent of Mexican American and African American women, and 75 percent of non-Hispanic White women indicated that based on their own experience, they felt that the attainment of an education was harder for minority women than for the non-Hispanic White women.

A majority of the respondents reported experiencing difficulties while pursuing higher education, including academic, emotional, and social problems. This was especially true for Mexican Americans, over two-thirds of whom reported difficulties in all three areas. African American women were least likely to report any emotional difficulties (41 percent) and non-Hispanic White women were less likely to report academic (40 percent) or social difficulties (46 percent). Ethnic and racial group differences were significant in all three areas.

The overall greater difficulty reported by Mexican American women is likely reflected in the perceived level of stress they experienced while pursuing their educational goals. On the Stress Scale, measuring factors related to the institutional environment as well as factors related to work, family, and personal problems, Mexican American women reported significantly higher levels of stress (mean 40.9) on institutional environment than the African American (mean 35.7) or non-Hispanic White (mean 37.2) women. On the scale measuring stress factors relating solely to family, employment, and personal problems, African American women reported significantly lower scores than the other two groups. In response to a four-point item that asked how frequently the women had felt stressed during college, over half of the Mexican American women reported feeling stressed frequently or most of the time compared to 42 percent of African Americans and 36 percent of non-Hispanic White respondents. To assess whether the women perceived support in their institutional environments, they were asked whether they felt supported by

TABLE 4.4
Ethnic Differences in Perceptions of Discrimination, Stress, and
Social Support by Ethnic Group

Higher Education Characteristic	Mexican American (300)	African American (100)	White (100)
Experienced Discrimination:			
Racial— Yes ($X^2(2) = 90.41, p < .01$)	68.50%	76.80%	19.20%
Gender— Yes ($X^2(2) = 7.30, p < .05$)	57.90%	42.60%	50.00%
Experienced Difficulties:			
Academic— Yes ($X^2(2) = 44.35, p < .01$)	74.40%	51.60%	40.00%
Emotional— Yes ($X^2(2) = 32.59, p < .01$)	84.90%	58.50%	67.00%
Social— Yes ($X^2(2) = 12.45, p < .01$)	63.20%	48.90%	45.50%
Reported Level of Total Stress While in School:			
Mean (SD) ($F(2) = 11.28, \text{Sig } F < .01$)	40.88 (10.19)	35.70 (9.57)	37.18 (8.88)
Institution Related Stress:			
Mean (SD) ($F(2) = 11.48, \text{Sig } F < .01$)	23.31 (7.28)	20.47 (6.23)	19.97 (6.11)
Work/Family/Personal Stress:			
Mean (SD) ($F(2) = 9.05, \text{Sig } F < .01$)	17.45 (4.68)	15.05 (5.11)	17.05 (4.47)
Felt Supported by Professors/ Advisors: Yes ($X^2(2) = 51.43, p < .01$)	45.10%	71.00%	81.60%

their professors and advisors while pursuing higher education. Mexican American women were more likely to report that they did not feel supported (55 percent) compared to 29 percent of African American and 18 percent of non-Hispanic White women.

Multivariate Analyses: Stress and Academic Difficulty

To examine the variation in stress experienced by the women while pursuing their higher education, as a function of predominantly institutional-related factors, multiple regression analyses were conducted with total stress score as the dependent variable, for all the women, for each ethnic group, and when controlling for the added difficulty of raising children while in school. Factors included in the model as intervening variables were: average number of hours worked weekly and level of perceived institutional support. Dummy variables were created for the following factors: financial aid (coded 1 for no aid); place of residence (coded 1 for living away from parental home); type of undergraduate institution (coded 1 for public); and the reported experience of race and sex discrimination and academic difficulty (coded 1 if experienced). The results from the analysis on the entire sample, as shown in table 4.5, demonstrate that the model was significant, accounting for 22 percent of the variation in reported stress levels (model $R^2 = .22$, Standard Error of Estimate = 8.88, signif. $F < .01$). Variables in the equation that significantly predicted higher stress included the experiences of race and sex discrimination, the experience of academic difficulty, the number of hours worked weekly, and place of residence.

Analyses were conducted on each ethnic group. For African American women, the only significant predictor of variation in stress was average number of hours worked per week, accounting for 8 percent of the variation. For non-Hispanic White women, the significant predictors of variation in stress were level of institutional support and sex discrimination, accounting for 14 percent of the variation. Higher perceived institutional support predicted lower stress levels. On the other hand, for Mexican American women, academic difficulty, and the experience of race and sex discrimination had significant effects on stress, together accounting for 18 percent of the variance.⁶ Logistic regression analyses were conducted for the total sample and for each ethnic group, predicting academic difficulty. The dependent variable, academic difficulty, initially measured on a scale ranging from 1, not difficult, to, 4, very difficult, was recoded (1,2 = 0, no difficulty, and 3,4 = 1, difficulty). The model included the following categorical variables: high school GPA (coded 1 for scores of 3 or less); hours worked in college (coded 1 for more than 15); place of residence (coded 1 for away from parental home); type of institution (coded 1 for public); institutional support (low support coded 1); financial aid (coded 1

TABLE 4.5
Multiple Regression: Perceived Level of Stress during
Higher Education

<i>Independent Variables</i>	<i>Regression Coefficient</i>	<i>Standard Error</i>	<i>Correlation C/ Total Stress</i>
(Intercept)	26.6428	3.1048	
Reported Academic Difficulty:	4.3525**	1.0717	.314
Experienced Racial Discrimination:	3.9323**	1.1798	.272
Average Weekly Hours Worked:	1.2099**	.4465	.268
Mexican American:	.7847	1.4351	.246
Experienced Sex Discrimination:	2.3350*	1.0390	.233
African American:	−3.0040	1.7589	−.161
Residence During College:	2.9480*	1.2220	.096
Financial Aid:	.1526	1.0177	−.017
Institutional Support:	.1007	.1382	.014
Type of Institution:	−1.0589	1.2107	−.003
Model R ² = .22, Standard Error = 8.88, F = 9.61, Signif F < .01			
Note: * p < .05; ** p < .01			

for no aid); and the experience of race and sex discrimination (coded 1 if experienced). Ethnicity was included in the analysis for the total sample. The results (not shown) suggest that the model was a fairly good fit for the Mexican American women (model $X^2(2) = 10.87, p < .01$) but less so for African Americans (model $X^2(1) = 6.56, p < .05$) and not significant for Whites. For Mexican Americans, two of the predictor variables had a statistically significant effect on the likelihood of experiencing academic difficulty. Working more than fifteen hours a week during college and experiencing racial discrimination significantly increased the odds of experiencing academic difficulty by factors of 2.49 and 1.91 respectively. For African American women who worked more than fifteen hours a week during college the odds of experiencing academic difficulty increased by a factor of 4.12.

Discussion

These respondents represent an historical cohort of high achieving women who graduated between 1978 and 1988, and benefited from affirmative action. The major findings of this study show:

- Women's access to higher education followed a staggered inequality entry model.
- Pre-college academic indicators such as HSGPA and being in a college bound group were similar across non-Hispanic White, African American, and Mexican American women.
- Significant differences in pre-college experiences are found for Mexican Americans in that they are less likely to report performing well and teacher's encouragement to attend college.
- Undergraduate experiences show similarities between African American and Mexican American as they report similar college GPA's and are significantly more likely than non-Hispanic White women to receive scholarships and student loans.
- Perceptions of institutional support are more likely to be reported by non-Hispanic Whites and least likely to be reported by Mexican American women with African American women in between.
- Academic, emotional, and social difficulties are most likely to be reported by Mexican American women.

In this chapter we argue that women's access to higher education followed a staggered inequality entry model to institutions of higher learning. Theorizing with an intersectional lens, the historical data reveal that in the hierarchically organized U.S. society, educational institutions gave non-Hispanic White women a social status that was more privileged than that found among historically underrepresented women at any time in U.S. history and in all parts of the country. Only in recent American history have Mexican American women accessed higher education at a significant level and their presence in U.S. institutions at the baccalaureate, master's, and doctoral level are still at a nascent stage (American Council on Education, 2004; Swail, Cabrera, & Lee, 2004; Watford, et al., 2006). However, while non-Hispanic Whites have increased degree attainment at all levels of the educational system, African American and Mexican American women have experienced uneven patterns in the modest gains made during the 1970s and early 1980s (Trent, 1991). Identity, understood as a multidimensional category rather than a unidimensional one, challenges the applicability of the feminist model as a paradigm to understand the experiences of all women. Gender is only one dimension that needs to be examined within an intersectional historical, social, and institutional framework to move beyond individual and culturally deterministic models that

ignore the role of institutional practices in promoting or hindering performance in pre-college and college experiences by gender, race, ethnicity, and socioeconomic status.

Pre-college educational experiences show that Mexican American women were the least likely to be encouraged to go to college in spite of being in a college-bound group, feeling well-prepared for college, and having similar HSGPAs to other groups. The lack of support from school personnel is an important determinant of a sense of self-confidence and has been found to significantly contribute to a woman's educational attainment (Tidball, 1980). For historically underrepresented young women, experiences in the pre-college educational pipeline such as lack of support from high school teachers and university professors and advisors has been found to increase stress and decrease the sense of self-confidence (Del Castillo, et al., 1988; Allen & Haniff, 1991). Prior studies show that Mexican American women may enter the university system with lower self-confidence due to non-supportive experiences in high schools (Lee, 1985, 1988; Zambrana & Zoppi, 2002). However, for Mexican American and African American women these influences are exacerbated when they are compounded by low socioeconomic status of the family of origin and limited financial resources during the college years (Zambrana, Dorrington, & Alonzo-Bell, 1997; Cardoza, 1991; Zambrana, 1988). The majority of Mexican American women were the first generation to attend college. Thus it seems likely that fewer family financial resources were available to the Mexican American women during their undergraduate experience. The data confirm that pursuit of a college education often represents a financial hardship for Mexican American students, as evidenced by the average number of hours worked per week, which may be associated with increased academic difficulties (Chacon, 1982; Anchor & Morales, 1990; Rodriguez, et al., 2000).

In examining the respondents' perception of perceived discrimination, academic difficulties, and institutional stress, distinct experiences emerge by ethnicity. In this study, about 50 percent of non-Hispanic White women report sex discrimination and two-fifths report experiencing academic difficulties. Interestingly their ability to persist and maintain their academic averages is perhaps mediated by a strong set of pre-college experiences that bolstered their sense of confidence in their academic abilities. In addition, a higher perception of support from professors and advisors suggests a more welcoming environment. These data contrast with earlier studies that found that non-Hispanic White women did not feel encouraged or supported by the faculty (Epstein, 1970; Feldman, 1974). Though not explored in this study, it can be speculated that this may in part be due to the increase in non-Hispanic White women peers and faculty at institutions of higher education during the 1970s and 1980s. Thus throughout the educational pipeline factors such as perceptions of teacher encouragement, high academic performance, and human

and cultural capital, along with knowledge of how to interact with professors, are all highly associated with self-confidence and have a positive influence on academic achievement in college.

Not unexpectedly, the majority of the African American women report racial discrimination (77 percent), while less than 50 percent report gender discrimination. Other studies confirm that for African American and Latino women, racial discrimination is more salient than gender discrimination and represents a "double jeopardy" (Gonzales, Blanton, & Williams, 2002; Howard-Vital, 1987). This perceived discrimination might have contributed to over half of the African American women experiencing academic difficulty and reporting significantly lower GPAs than non-Hispanic White women. Apart from the shared experience of discrimination, in contrast to the Mexican American women, African American women in this study appear more likely to experience academic and social integration while in college as evidenced by greater perceived support from professors and advisors (Tinto, 1987, 1988). African American women experienced less overall stress, whether related to the institution or to their work, family, and personal lives, were less likely to experience academic, emotional, or social difficulties during college, and were more likely to report encouragement to go to college while in high school. For African American women, the presence of a group of African American peers during their undergraduate experience, whether they attended an Historically Black College or University or had a sorority which could provide support combined with financial assistance may also be associated with less perceived stress and academic difficulty.

Although the African American and Mexican American women shared similar experiences of discrimination, Mexican American women report the highest levels of sex discrimination, academic, emotional, and social difficulty, and the highest levels of stress and the lowest level of support from professors and advisors. Limited experience with dominant culture individuals, due to the likelihood of coming from more segregated communities and schools, from families with less education than their college counterparts, fewer social networks on campus and limited financial options may account for the differences between Mexican American women and the other two groups (Hernandez, 1990; Chacon, 1982; Gandara, 1982; Capello, 1994). These findings underscore the importance of understanding the different factors, which influence the lives of middle-class non-Hispanic White women and those of low-income and middle-income African American and Mexican American women. Further within group differences by SES of family of origin and race/ethnicity require exploration in order not to essentialize the experiences of all historically underrepresented women.

Extending the theoretical paradigms to include family of origin SES, pre-college experiences and perceptions of support are dimensions to be included

in any further inquiry to avoid any assumptions regarding a “level playing field” for all women. These data also provide a more authentic, compelling and profound understanding of the realities of what Feagin, Vera, and Imani called “The Agony of Education” (1996). Many of the same factors historically underrepresented women identified in the 1970s and 1980s as barriers remain in place, providing additional insight into the reasons for the sustained low participation of Mexican American women, in particular, and African American women in institutions of higher education. These data challenge current university systems that maintain a status quo by advocating for an undifferentiated set of policies “for all women” or “all minorities,” which has simply maintained a “survival of the fittest” policy. Institutions of higher learning have engaged in a minimal policy modifications approach that masks racial and ethnic educational disparities in retention and degree completion of historically underrepresented women. Multiple recommendations have been heralded as ways to break the disturbing and unequal historical patterns of social and racial inequality in the United States. Access to higher education is a major vehicle for social change and social justice. Bold university leadership is required to reverse entrenched patterns of inequality for historically underrepresented women.

NOTES

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2. Table 261, Bachelor's Degrees Conferred by Degree-Granting Institutions, by Racial/Ethnic Group & Sex of Students, 1976–2003–04. National Center for Education Statistics.
3. Table 267, Bachelor's Degrees Conferred by Degree-Granting Institutions, by Racial/Ethnic Group & Sex of Students, 1976–2003–04. National Center for Education Statistics.
4. Thomas P. Carter, *MAs in School: A History of Educational Neglect*. New York: College Entrance Examination Board, 1970, 31; this percentage is affirmed in the comprehensive study funded by the Ford Foundation of which Thomas P. Carter also participated and published as *The Mexican-American People: The Nation's Second Largest Minority*. New York: Free Press, 1970, 142–179.
5. Cronbach's alpha is used as a measure of reliability of a psychometric instrument. A high value (close to 1.0) indicates a strong relationship among the dimensions on the scale.
6. Separate multiple regression analyses were performed to control for the added difficulty of raising children while attending college. When women with children were

excluded from the sample, significant factors predicting higher stress among women with no children during undergraduate school included, the experience of academic difficulties, race and sex discrimination, residence away from home, and Mexican American ethnicity. These variables accounted for 26 percent of the variation in stress.

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